

Session 1 — The Whole Map

The opening night · what you know behind what you say

Read **docs/PRIMER.md** first — that carries the 1400-year narrative. This document covers only what session 1 specifically needs: the muqaddima material behind the two-paradigms slide, the three preview figures, and the questions an opening night attracts.

1. The two paradigms — what is actually in your source

The slide gives four minutes. Behind it, pp. 48–49 of the muqaddima argue this at length. What matters for you:

- The Islamic tradition uniquely layered **dirāya** (weighing the content by reason) on top of **riwāya** (the chain of transmission). That combination is the claim — not the chain alone.
- Which is why reports are *rejected* when reason refuses them, even where a chain exists.
- The fairness point matters more than the contrast: **they work hard; they simply have no isnād system**. Do not mock. The room will respect restraint more than scorn, and the venue expects it.

Tareekh-e-Ummat, muqaddima, pp. 48–49 · riwāya / dirāya set out at pp. 63–64

The three sayings on that page — you only use the first

Page 57 carries three, from three different authorities. The script uses Sufyān al-Thawrī. The other two are your spare material if the segment runs short or someone asks for more:

إِذَا اتَّهَمْتُمْ فَحَاسِبُوهُ بِالسِّنِينَ

“When you suspect a man, hold him to account by the years.” — Ḥaḥṣ ibn Ghiyāth

لَمْ يُسْتَعَنْ عَلَى الْكَذَّابِينَ بِمِثْلِ التَّارِيخِ

“Nothing has helped against liars like history.” — Ḥammād ibn Zayd

Tareekh-e-Ummat, muqaddima, p. 57 — all three on the same page, verified

The spare story, if you have four minutes

A report circulated that al-Ma’mūn once made Imām al-Shāfi‘ī drink enough wine to fell an ordinary man, and it had no effect on him. Ibn Ḥajar, in *Lisān al-Mīzān*, killed it in two moves: **the chain fails** — al-Shāfi‘ī’s meeting al-Ma’mūn is not established at all; and **reason refuses it** — this is a man who said he would give up even cold water if it dulled his mind.

Tareekh-e-Ummat, muqaddima, p. 57

This is riwāya and dirāya demonstrated in thirty seconds — chain first, then reason — without either word being taught. Better than any definition. Hold it in reserve.

2. The forged Khaybar document — hold it for session 3

Fifth century AH. The Jews of Baghdad produce a very old-looking document at court: the Prophet ﷺ had exempted them from jizya after Khaybar. It carries the signatures of ‘Alī[ؓ], Sa‘d ibn Mu‘ādh[ؓ] and Mu‘āwiya[ؓ]. The document looks genuinely ancient. The Muslims are ready to grant the exemption.

Before the decision, it is shown to al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī[ؒ], who declares it forged at a glance, on two grounds: Mu‘āwiya[ؓ] accepted Islam *after* Khaybar, so he could not have signed; and Sa‘d ibn Mu‘ādh[ؓ] had died at Khandaq, years before it.

Tareekh-e-Ummat, muqaddima, p. 58 — verified, read off the page

Do not spend this tonight. It is the strongest single story in the whole muqaddima and it belongs in session 3, where the room needs to understand that fabrications about the Companions[ؓ] exist and get caught. Using it on the opening night wastes it.

3. The three preview figures

All three panels are unsourced and must not be delivered as printed. ‘Umar[ؓ] can be filled from Siyar A‘lām al-Nubalā’ (Rāshidūn section) this week. Hulagu and Mehmed have **no work on the current shelf** — al-Bidāya ends around 774 AH.

If nothing is verified by the night: introduce ‘Umar[ؓ] properly, name the other two in one sentence each as “you will meet him in session 6 / session 7”, and move on. That is honest and costs you nothing. Do not fill the gap from memory.

Hulagu’s incident must not be the fall of Baghdad. That is tonight’s opening scene — the تعارف segment would simply repeat the first five minutes.

4. The opening-night questions

“Whose book is this, and why his?”

The honest answer, which you have agreed to give plainly: the course is based on *Tareekh-e-Ummat* by Maulana Muhammad Ismail Rehan. It was chosen because it stays close to the primary sources, carries its own footnoted citations, and is written within a settled Sunni frame — so the course narrates a book rather than an individual’s reading of history. Where it does not reach a period, a second named work is used and **named to you**.

“Are you a scholar / historian?”

No — and say so without apology. It is the reason for the method, not a weakness in it: every claim traces to a printed page, and nothing is asserted on your own authority. This is the same paragraph you give in آغاز; if asked, simply repeat it.

“Will you cover Karbala / the disputes among the Companions*?”

Yes, in sessions 3 and 4, and each opens with the fuqahā’s own rules for reading such events. Nothing on those topics tonight. Deferral line is on the cue card.

“Why stop at 1947?”

Because after 1947 it is living politics rather than history, and this is a history course. Say it plainly and do not elaborate — the venue has ruled this out and a short answer is the strongest one.

“Isn’t the caliphate the real subject?” — *likely in this room*

It is a large part of it: session 4 is precisely how a consultative office became a hereditary throne, and session 7 ends at 1924. **But do not draw the conclusion for them tonight.** Say what is coming, and let those two evenings do their own work with the sources in front of them.

5. Why the course is shaped this way — if anyone asks

CHOICE	REASON
Whole span in week 1	Every later evening needs somewhere to attach. Without the frame, week 6 is just another story.
They write, rather than listen	A timeline you marked yourself is remembered; one you were shown is not.

Three people per evening, never more	Thirty names across ten weeks is already at the limit of what a weekly audience retains.
Conclusions always quoted, never asserted	The speaker is not a scholar. Every lesson carries a name and a page, so a challenge is answered by pointing at the screen.
Sensitive material fenced first	Session 3 installs the fuqahā's ruling before anything disputed is narrated.

6. Pending for this session

The opening scene. Baghdad 656 is currently narrated from general knowledge. It needs the Mongol volume — the caliph's name, the manner of the city's fall, and what the chroniclers say became of the libraries. **Until that exists, keep the scene short and general:** the city was taken, the caliph was killed, the libraries were destroyed. Do not add detail you cannot cite.

What survived 656. The single most important idea in the evening — that the civilisation survived because books and scholars had already moved — is also unsourced. Say it as a general statement, not with specifics, until it is.

Every date in the deck and script carries [verify] until checked against *Tareekh-e-Ummat*.